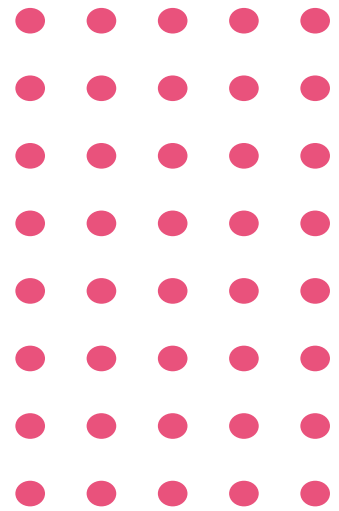


Diploma in Leadership and Management

The importance of diversity

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Lesson outcomes

The student will be able to understand the fundamentals of diversity management. The students will be able to identify areas of improvement in their own organisations

Introduction

The founder of Honda once said:

"If you hire only those people you understand, the company will never get people better than you are. Always remember that you often find outstanding people among those you don't particularly like."

Did you know?

78% of employees who responded to a Harvard Business Review (HBR) study said they work at organizations that lack diversity in leadership positions.

Diversity management is a topic that cannot be ignored. Employees are placing pressure on companies to take the necessary steps to include diversity in the workforce. This should not be a punishment for any company, and we need more managers and leaders to see the value of diversity management

According to Sara Porterfield, A lack of diversity in the leadership of an organization hampers innovation, prohibits members of minority groups from being recognized for their contributions, and fails to meet client expectations.

According to CNN money, The millennial and Gen Z generations are the most diverse in history: only 56% of the 87 million millennials in the country are white, as compared to 72% of the 76 million members of the baby boomer generation.

Key reading materials:

- <https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/5-must-read-books-todays-inclusive-leader-james-wright/>
- <https://business.linkedin.com/talent-solutions/blog/talent-on-tap/2019/steps-leaders-must-take-to-create-diverse-inclusive-teams>
- <https://edition.cnn.com/2019/03/05/success/diversity-fatigue-resistance/index.html>
- <https://hbr.org/2019/11/how-the-best-bosses-interrupt-bias-on-their-teams>



Who is responsible for inclusion?

According to (Robins, n.d.) “Research also shows that teams that operate in an inclusive culture outperform their peers by a staggering 80 percent.” Deloitte

When you leave it up to HR to do everything related to inclusion, it does not work. HR is not able to do everything on their own. HR needs the support from all company managers and leaders.

The company needs buy-in from all individuals of the company. When CEOs delegate the inclusion project to someone else or another department with no input from themselves, the CEO has failed. Inclusion must come from the top and have the involvement from top managers and leaders.

Top tip for catching your own bias:

Mentally flip whoever you are dealing with in a specific situation with someone else and see how it feels. If it feels weird then you probably have a bias. For example, flip it from man to a woman to see if you have a gender bias, as stated by (Robins, n.d.)



Expert advice when it comes to building an inclusive workplace:

See people and not just workers:

Ideally, we all want to have a work identity and your personal identity outside of work but as we spend more time at work, those identities start to overlap. We need to look at employees as

people and not just a number. This means looking at the needs of those you work with. Looking at what people are going through and understanding how to better support them. Support can be in the form of communicating with the employee in a way that makes them comfortable, in having a 1-on-1 check in and following up.

Get through the tension:

The outside world has an impact on your employees. We need to understand how outside issues like politics, the news and social justice plays into the life's of the employees that we manage. Whether it touches on health, religion, sexuality and race, we need to be aware of what is happening.

Tip: Whether it was an act of violence on a specific community that is represented within your company, or recurring events in the news regarding mental illness, gather your team and let them know that you recognize the impact. Ask if anyone needs some time off, and remind them you have an open door policy should they need to talk, as stated by (Robins, n.d.)

Level the playing field:

As the manager or leader, you have a lot of power and influence in your team and the company. You have the power to step in and address issues and to correct negative behaviours that employees are displaying.

Think of the following actions:

- Stop harmful language
 - Listen to and promote underrepresented voices
 - Give credit
-

- Delegate and empower
- Question and challenge the norm

Diversity and inclusion activities to build a stronger workforce:



Learn What Has Shaped People

Create a safe space to learn about your employees' backgrounds and what has been vital in shaping their lives. Doing this as a group allows employees to learn new things about each other that otherwise might not come up, and the act of being open, honest and vulnerable is a great way to form bonds, increase empathy and improve relationships.

- Ask everyone to think about the three most defining moments in their lives and write them down on separate Post-its.
- Have each employee present these moments to the team, and share their story to whatever degree they feel comfortable.
- Thank everyone for sharing and ask the team to share what their takeaways are from the exercise.

Find Out How People Feel

Employees have lives and experiences outside of the office that inform the way they feel, and therefore perform at work. Understanding how people feel before a group brainstorm or meeting, for example, will shed light on their level of participation, the dynamic they bring to the group, and it will bring team empathy to the forefront.

Use the following conversation-starter in small groups to kick off a meeting, or try it during a one-on-one to set the tone for openness and vulnerability. It also gives the employee a moment to reflect on how they are feeling, which is something we don't often take the time to do.

- Go around the table and have everyone on your team finish this statement: "If you really knew me, you'd know that..."

It can be something as simple as: "I missed the bus this morning so I feel a bit stressed. I need a minute to collect myself." Or, something a bit more revealing such as: "I have a family member who is not well and I'm having trouble focusing".

Diversity and inclusion workshop and activity ideas:

Find Out How People Feel



This is the first and foremost important activity to promote and maintain diversity and inclusion in the workplace. Team managers can arrange monthly seatings to discuss and design the different diversity acts.

For example: Employees with different backgrounds can brief what religious days or holidays are important to them and in what ways. Accordingly, they can be offered the time off.

This spreads historical and cultural knowledge among co-workers and increases interpersonal understanding with the fewest possible side effects.

Diversity and Inclusion (D&I) In Flower Petals

This recreational activity needs 4-10 members in each group and it is one of the best ways to learn more about each other. All the members should be encouraged to make the best of their creativity and ideas. Here's how to proceed –

- All the groups should get a large art paper and some colorful markers.
- Each group has to draw a large flower. It should have a round center and an equal number of petals to the number of participants in their group.
- After discussion, each participant should fill the petals with something that is unique about themselves- anything that makes them stand out from others. However, physical characteristics should be ignored.
- The center of the flower should be filled with their 'common' something.
- The flowers should be shared with the other groups so as to discuss the differences and similarities.

This game provides mental exercise and a wide scope for social interaction.

Post The Story-Links

Internal communication tools can be of great help to promote diversity and inclusion in the workplace. A web of inclusions can be created in the form of stories or real-life incidents. It should be described in a way that shows what makes them unique and posted on the online employee community platform of your company. As others see the previous posts, they look for self connections and add to the link.

For example: One employee writes, “India is my national origin.”, the next person who can relate to it adds, “I once visited India when I was a kid.” and so on... This activity gives coworkers an opportunity to start a conversation on various topics and compare how they are the same or different.

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